Attached is a paper that was published in February 2014 titled "Does Class Size Matter" by Dr. Diane Whitmore Schanzenbach. It is an academic review of the research that has been done on class sizes and the relationship to student outcomes. Currently Dr. Schanzenbach is the director of the Institute for Policy Research and Faculty Fellow at Northwestern University, and the Margaret Walker Alexander Professor in the School of Education and Social Policy.

Some excerpts from her publication:

These critics are mistaken. Class size matters. Research supports the common-sense notion that children learn more and teachers are more effective in smaller classes.
This policy brief summarizes the academic literature on the impact of class size and finds that class size is an important determinant of a variety of student outcomes, ranging from test scores to broader life outcomes. Smaller classes are particularly effective at raising achievement levels of low-income and minority children.

Class size is one of the most studied education policies, and an extremely rigorous body of research demonstrates the importance of class size in positively influencing student achievement. The modern research paradigm strongly prefers the use of research designs that can credibly isolate the cause-and-effect relationship between inputs and outcomes. Scholars generally agree that true randomized experiments, such as the Project STAR class-size experiment described below, are the "gold standard" for isolating causal impacts.

The mechanisms at work linking small classes to higher achievement include a mixture of higher levels of student engagement, increased time on task, and the opportunity small classes provide for high-quality teachers to better tailor their instruction to the students in the class. For example, observations of STAR classrooms found that in small classes students spent more time on task, and teachers spent more time on instruction and less on classroom management.

There are substantial positive impacts from class-size reduction from an average of 22 to an average of 15. In fact, the class sizes targeted in STAR were informed by influential work by Glass and Smith that found strong impacts from class sizes below 20. Based on this, some researchers conclude that the evidence supports better outcomes only if classes are below some threshold number such as 15 or 20. Sometimes the argument is extended to suggest that reducing class size is not effective unless classes are reduced to within this range. The broader pattern in the literature finds positive impacts from class-size reductions using variation across a wider range of class sizes, including class-size reductions mandated by maximum class-size rules set at 30 (Sweden) or 40 (Israel).

The weight of the evidence suggests that class-size impacts might be more or less linear across the range of class sizes observed in the literature—that is, from roughly 15 to 40 students per class.

The academic literature strongly supports the common-sense notion that class size is an important determinant of student outcomes. Class-size reduction has been shown to improve a variety of measures, ranging from contemporaneous test scores to later-life outcomes such as college completion The study finds that smaller class sizes in eighth grade have a positive impact on test scores and measures of student engagement, and finds some evidence that these impacts are larger in urban schools.

Dr. Schanzenbach cites 41 references in her paper and has these conclusions and recommendations:

Based on the research literature,

- The payoff from class-size reduction is larger for low-income and minority children
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- Policymakers should carefully weigh the efficacy of class-size-reduction policy against other potential uses of funds. While lower class size has a demonstrable cost, it may prove the more cost-effective policy overall